

Multilingualism & Language Diversity (cont.)

LING 150C, Week 6

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2026-10-01

Journal (5 min)

Choose one option and write silently. We'll hear from a couple of people afterward.

Option A

Have you ever noticed a group (a friend group, a team, your hometown) deliberately speaking differently from a neighboring group, almost as a way of saying “we’re not them”? What did that look like?

Option B

Describe a word or phrase that’s specific to your family, hometown, or friend group — something an outsider wouldn’t get. What would be lost if you stopped using it?

~5 min: 4 min silent writing, then 1-2 volunteers share.

Today’s Plan

1. Activity: Research a Pacific Country
2. Your Discussion Questions
3. [Agenda item 3]
4. [Agenda item 4]

Activity: Research a Pacific Country

In your group: research your assigned country/territory on Wikipedia or another reliable source. You have 8 minutes.

1. New Caledonia
2. Tonga

3. Federated States of Micronesia
4. Indonesian Papua
5. Solomon Islands
6. French Polynesia

Answer as a group:

- How many indigenous languages does it have? What's your source?
- What's the metropolitan (colonial/official) language?
- Is there a pidgin, creole, or *lingua franca* used across language groups?
- Which of today's three factors best explains its level of diversity?
- Anything that doesn't fit the patterns we discussed today?

~8 min research time. Groups have laptops. Circulate while they work.

Compare and Constrast

1. **Report** Each group gives a 1-2 minute rundown of what they found — the numbers, the languages, and their factor hypothesis.
2. **Track it** As groups report, jot each one on the shared doc: indigenous language count, metropolitan language, pidgin/creole (y/n), best-fit factor.
3. **Look at the board** Once all six are up, look across the whole set together — what patterns jump out?

Discuss: Which factor came up most often as the best explanation across the six?
Did any country not fit neatly into the patterns from Tuesday?

~8 min research time. Groups have laptops. Circulate while they work.

[Three-Stat Example]

[Number]

[caption]

[Number]

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Your Discussion Posts

From Your Discussion Posts

Great questions and connections came in on Chapter 7 — let's dig into a few.

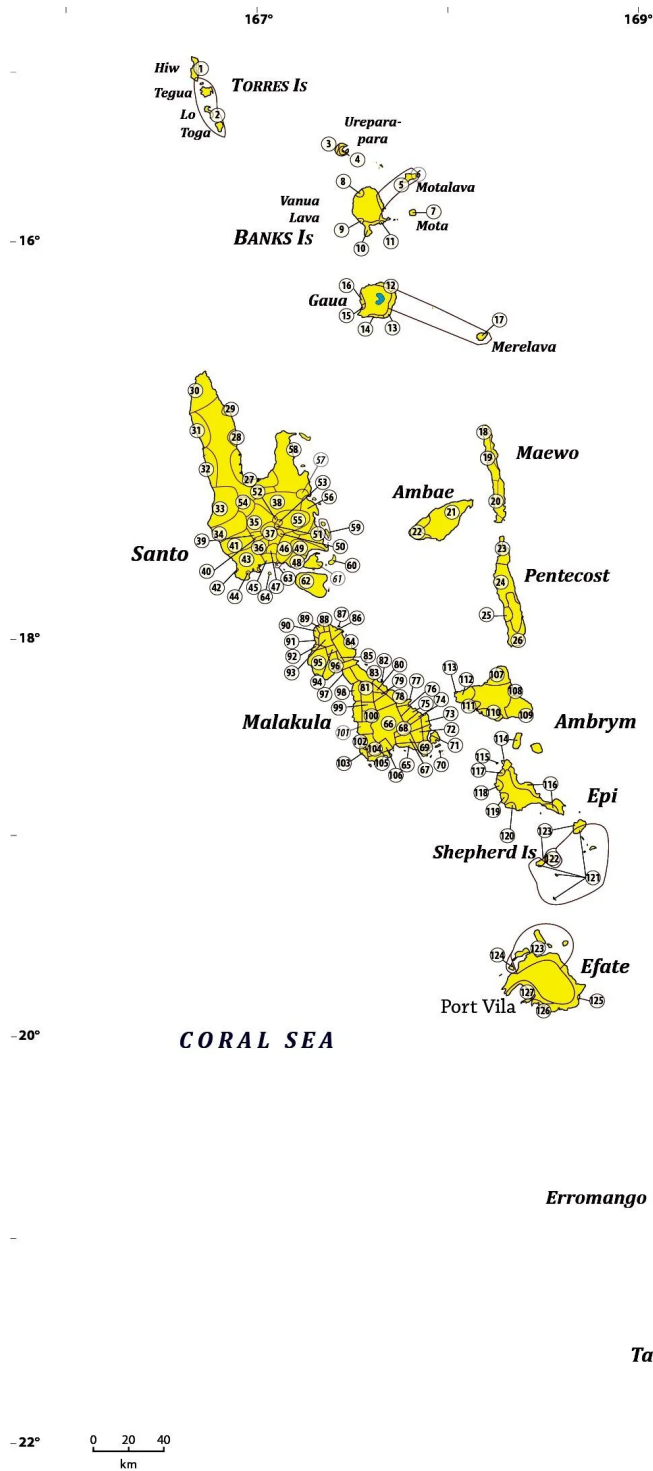
Opening framing slide. Names the three threads we're pulling from student posts before diving into each.

Vanuatu, Revisited

Michael asked: how can one small island group have languages so different that neighboring islands can't understand each other?

Dyllan asked: when a language is only spoken by a few hundred people and isn't being passed to kids, what happens next — and does losing the language mean losing parts of the culture?

Discuss: What would it take for a language with a few hundred speakers to survive another generation?



The languages of Vanuatu

1	Hiw	59	Mavea
2	Lo-Toga	60	Tutuba
3	Lehali	61	Aore
4	Löyöp	62	Tamambo
5	Mwotlap	63	Tangoa
6	Volow	64	Araki
7	Mota	65	Axamb
8	Lemerig	66	Lendamboi
9	Vera'a	67	Nasvang
10	Vurés	68	Sörsörän
11	Mwesen	69	Avok
12	Nume	70	Uliveo
13	Dorig	71	Port Sandwich
14	Koro	72	Nisvai
15	Olrat	73	Burmbar
16	Lakon	74	Mbwenelang
17	Mwerlap	75	Aulua
18	Sungwadia	76	Niolean
19	Sungwadaga	77	Rerep
20	Baetora	78	Unua
21	Ambae	79	Nitita
22	West Ambae	79	Viviti
23	Raga	81	Avava
24	Apima	82	Neverver
25	Ske	83	Litzlitz
26	Saa	84	Uripiv
27	Tolomako	85	Rutan
28	Piamatsina	86	Botovro
29	Yunapu	87	Vao
30	Valpei	88	Alovas
31	Nokuku	89	Vovo
32	Meri	90	Nese
33	Wusi	91	Najit
34	Bura	92	Malua Bay
35	Merei	93	Njav
36	Mores	94	Tirax
37	Ande	95	V'ënen Taut
38	Toksiki	96	Tape
39	Kiai	97	Larévat
40	Moiso	98	Neve'ei
41	Kene	99	Nivat
42	Daruru	100	Nasarian
43	Akei	101	Aveteian
44	Redlahtur	102	Ninde
45	Wailapa	103	Nahavaq
46	Farsaf	104	Näti
47	Varavara	105	Naha'ai
48	Narmoris	106	Navwien
49	Billiru	107	North Ambrym
50	Atin	108	Orkon
51	Ati	109	Southeast Ambrym
52	Farnanto	110	Daakie
53	Butmas-Tur	111	Daakaka
54	Sinia	112	Dalkalaen
55	Farfi	113	Raljago
56	Ngen	114	Paama
57	Tholp	115	Lamen
58	Sakao	116	Lewo
		117	Bierebo
		118	Baki
		119	Mkir
		120	Bieria
		121	Namakura
		122	Emae
		123	Nakanamanga
		124	Lelepa
		125	Eton
		126	South Efate
		127	Mele-Fila
		128	Sie
		129	Ura
		130	Utaha
		131	North Tanna
		132	Lenakel
		133	Southwest Tanna
		134	Whitesands
		135	Kwamera
		137	Anejom
		138	Futuna-Aniwa

François et al., eds (2015). *The languages of Vanuatu: Unity and diversity*. Canberra: SLIM.

Tie back to Tuesday’s three factors (time, separation, social structure) — Vanuatu is the extreme case of all three stacking together.

Dyllan’s question, updated: Crowley (2000) famously argued Bislama posed no real threat to Vanuatu’s indigenous languages. A 2025 review (Lavender Forsyth) challenges that — 2020 census data show only 14% of Vanuatu’s population now speaks an indigenous language as their first language, and in rural areas as many as 1 in 5 people aged 4-20 have Bislama, not an indigenous language, as their first language. That’s the mechanism behind Dyllan’s question: kids growing up with Bislama at home instead of the local language breaks the chain of transmission. Don’t over-explain this — just flag it, since full language endangerment is covered in a later unit.

Why So Many Languages?

Linguist Alexandre François has spent decades documenting this exact puzzle in northern Vanuatu (the Torres and Banks Islands).

- **17 languages, 9,400 people** — all descended from one ancestor language, 3,000 years of divergence
- **Isolation alone doesn’t explain it** — people there are constantly in contact: trading, intermarrying, visiting
- **Language as identity marker:** communities *deliberately* keep their speech different from close, friendly neighbors — François calls this language’s “emblematic function”
- **Egalitarian multilingualism:** no village outranks another, so no variety becomes “the” prestige language — everyone just learns their neighbors’ languages instead

The dynamics of linguistic diversity: egalitarian multilingualism and power imbalance among northern Vanuatu languages

ALEXANDRE FRANÇOIS

Figure 1: François (2012)

Discuss: If isolation alone doesn't explain Vanuatu's diversity, what does this suggest about places that *are* very isolated but still only have one language?

Direct answer to Michael's and Dyllan's questions, grounded in François (2011, 2012). Key reframe: diversity isn't an accident of geography, it's maintained on purpose. Also sets up Dyllan's endangerment question — the same egalitarian multilingualism that sustains tiny languages today is exactly what's eroding under colonial-era disruption and modern schooling (mention briefly, don't dive deep — save for later unit on endangerment).

Zooming Out: Is This Just Vanuatu?

- **Not unique to the Pacific:** linguists call this pattern “small-scale” or “egalitarian” multilingualism — the same setup (many small languages, no prestige hierarchy, everyone multilingual) is documented in West Africa, the Amazon, and northern Australia too (Lüpke 2016; Pakendorf, Dobrushina & Khanina 2021)
- **A bigger claim:** linguist Nicholas Evans (2018) argues this may be close to the *ancestral* human condition — that language itself likely evolved in multilingual small-scale societies, not isolated monolingual ones
- If he's right, multilingualism isn't the exception that needs explaining — monolingual nation-states are the historically recent, unusual case

Discuss: If small-scale multilingualism was the human norm for most of history, why does monolingualism feel like the “default” to so many people today?

~5 min. Good note to end the Vanuatu thread on: reframes the whole unit. Monolingualism isn't neutral/natural — it's a product of nation-state language policy, mass schooling, and standardization, which is a much more recent development than multilingual small-scale societies. Don't need to resolve the discuss prompt — just let it sit before moving to Kale's question.

Language and Local Knowledge

Kale's connection: in BOT 444 (Ethnoecology), Kale has studied how Indigenous and Local Knowledge (ILK) develops over generations through a community's relationship with its environment — and noticed this tracks closely with how Lynch describes language diverging through geographic and social separation.

Kale's question: could neighboring language groups in Melanesia have different names, classifications, or knowledge systems for the same plants and animals?

Discuss: If language and ecological knowledge both diverge through isolation, which one do you think usually changes first?

This is a strong interdisciplinary connection — worth explicitly praising in class. If no one has a confident answer to the discuss prompt, that's fine; the point is raising the possibility that linguistic diversity and biocultural diversity are entangled, not resolving it today.

Kale's Question, Globally

David Harmon (1996) compared the countries with the most endemic languages (found nowhere else) to the countries with the most endemic vertebrate species (mammals, reptiles, birds, amphibians found nowhere else).

- **64% overlap** between the top 25 countries on each list
- **Papua New Guinea ranks #1** for endemic languages (847) *and* in the top 10 for endemic vertebrate species
- His explanation: the same conditions — rugged terrain, isolation, small-scale societies — that let species diverge into new forms also let languages diverge into new forms. One doesn't cause the other; both are downstream of the same isolation

Discuss: Harmon's explanation is about geographic *isolation* producing both effects in parallel. How does this compare to François's claim (from the Vanuatu slides) that language diversity is partly deliberate, not just a byproduct of isolation? Could both be true at once?

Answers Kale's question at the macro/statistical level: diversity of language and diversity of species co-occur geographically, worldwide, not just impressionistically in Melanesia. Harmon (1996), *Southwest Journal of Linguistics*. Good moment to have students hold two explanations in tension rather than picking one — isolation-as-shared-cause (Harmon) vs. deliberate differentiation (François) aren't mutually exclusive.

Example

A concrete case: the Kalam people of the Upper Kaironk Valley, Papua New Guinea highlands (~13,000 speakers).

Zoology (Bulmer 1967): Kalam classify cassowaries *separately* from all other birds — not by mistake, but because cassowaries occupy a unique role in Kalam thought and ritual. Their system also sorts animals by habitat (forest vs. garden vs. homestead; aerial vs. terrestrial vs. underground), not just by body shape the way Western biology does.



Botany (Gardner 2010): Kalam distinguish roughly 500 named plants — many finer-grained than Western scientific species, some grouping things Western botany splits apart.

Discuss: Bulmer titled his paper “Why is the cassowary not a bird?” What does it tell us that this is a real, serious research question?

This is the direct, concrete answer to Kale’s original question — yes, a documented Melanesian group has a classification system for plants/animals that diverges meaningfully from both Western science and (presumably) from neighboring groups, though a direct neighbor-to-neighbor comparison wasn’t found in this search. Emphasize: Kalam taxonomy isn’t “wrong” or “primitive” — it’s organized around different, equally coherent criteria (ritual significance, habitat, practical use) rather than evolutionary descent.

This Research Is Happening Right Now

A 2024 PhD dissertation — from right here at UH Mānoa — documented exactly this kind of plant knowledge for the Abui people of Alor Island, eastern Indonesia (A.L. Blake, advised by Gary Holton). It’s a direct, current answer to Kale’s question about *how* a group actually classifies plants.

Names encode different kinds of knowledge, not just appearance:

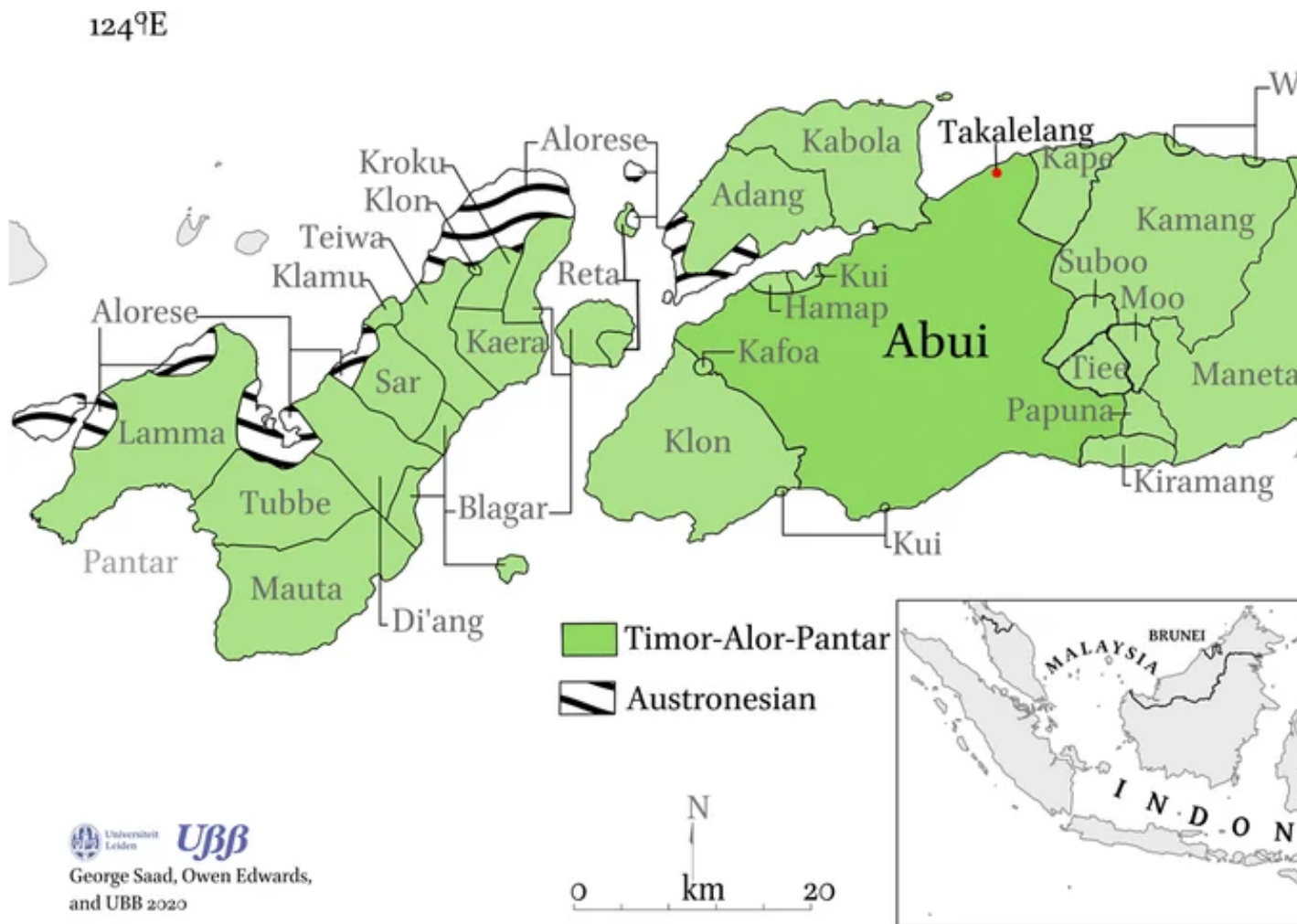
- *al fiyaai* “nettlespurge,” lit. “Islam candlenut” — two plants that look nothing alike, linked because both were burned for lamp oil; the name preserves *history*, not shape
- *fia beeka* “fern bad” — marks a fern as inedible, in contrast to “good” (edible) ferns — classification by *utility*
- *kupai meeting* “forest betel-vine” — classification by *habitat*

Metaphor drives the categories, often from the body or animals:

- *kaai hawet* “Ziziphus,” lit. “dog its teeth” (thorns)
- *wata muur* “pomelo,” lit. “coconut citrus” (fruit size)
- *katiki* “Conyza,” lit. “loincloth broke” (shredded-looking leaves)

Discuss: Western botany classifies primarily by evolutionary descent. Abui plant names show at least five other organizing logics — history, utility, habitat, body-part metaphor, taxonomic prototype. Is any one of these more “correct” than the others?

This is the most direct, current answer to Kale’s actual question. Good closing move on the Kale thread: shows this isn’t settled 1960s-70s scholarship (Bulmer) — it’s live research, happening now, at Andy’s own institution, on a different island group from Vanuatu/PNG, reinforcing that this pattern isn’t one-off. The “metaphor hardening into taxonomy” point (alokai example) is worth dwelling on — it shows folk classification isn’t a fixed system handed down unchanged, it’s actively being renegotiated as new plants and new generations enter the picture.



Multilingualism as Identity

Chloe's post: growing up in Hawai'i with a Chinese family background, Chloe noticed she speaks differently depending on who she's talking to — English at school, another language at home — and connected this to why multilingualism is so common across the Pacific.

Discuss: Think of a time you (or someone you know) switched languages or ways of speaking depending on who you were talking to. What triggered the switch?

~5-7 min. This personalizes the material — don't let it stay abstract. If the room is quiet, offer your own example first.

For Tuesday

- Quiz 2 closes **Friday, October 2 at 11:59pm**
- Read [Ch. 9 - The Languages of Micronesia \(Bender\)](#) (13 pgs.)
- **Keep in mind:** Writing Assignment 1 First Draft due **Friday, October 9 at 11:59pm**

Week 7 Overview ▾



This week surveys two of the Pacific's three major culture areas. Bender's chapter introduces the nations and languages of **Micronesia**, and Schütz's chapter traces the origins and spread of the **Polynesian** languages using evidence from archaeology (including Lapita pottery), genetics, and comparative linguistics.

This week's reading(s):

- Before Tuesday's class (10/6): [Ch. 9 - The Languages of Micronesia \(Bender\)](#) (13 pgs.)
- Before Thursday's class (10/8): [Ch. 10 - Polynesian Languages \(Schütz\)](#) (15 pgs.)

Due this week:

- Writing Assignment 1 First Draft due **Friday, October 9 at 11:59pm**
- Quiz #3 opens Friday, October 9 and closes **Monday, October 12 at 11:59pm**

~4 min. Exit ticket, silent writing.